

Syllabus: Metaphysics

PHIL-UA 78

Fall 2024

Professor: Cian Dorr

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Office hours: MW 12.30–1.30pm or by appointment

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1. Course description

Metaphysics is the branch of philosophy that investigates the nature of reality at a general level. Although it includes a huge array questions about many specific phenomena—Could a person survive the complete replacement of their body by a new body? Could a table have been originally constituted from an entirely different hunk of wood? Do fictional characters like Sherlock Holmes exist?—the significance of these questions often turns in part on their relevance to the evaluation of theories that aim at some kind of comprehensive description of reality as a whole. This course will be a rigorous introduction to metaphysics, from the point of view of contemporary analytic philosophy. The topics covered may include: necessity and possibility; identity and distinctness; law and chance; causation and explanation; time and change; time travel and its paradoxes; existence and non-existence; part and whole; properties and relations; definability and fundamentality.

2. Assessment

Midterm exam	25%
Final exam	35%
Term paper	30%
Participation	10%

The ‘participation’ grade is based on your effort, preparedness, and contributions to discussion.

3. Expectations

This will be a *lecture-based* course: you are expected to carefully follow the points made in the lectures, checking your understanding when things seem unclear by asking questions in lecture, discussion section, and office hours. The readings are also very important. But they are mostly ‘primary sources’—classic papers in analytic philosophy, not written with an eye to the needs of undergraduates encountering the relevant topics for the first time. There will be lots of references to other authors and ideas you probably haven’t encountered, and you shouldn’t expect to follow everything: I will try to make it clear which bits are really important and should be read closely; which bits can be skipped; and which bits are in neither of the above categories.

The readings will not be a good substitute for the lectures. For example, I may sometimes say something like ‘Here, the author treats such-and-such claim as obviously true, or as obviously following from such-and-such other claim, but it’s really not obvious at all because...’. If in your exam or term paper *you* treat the claim or inference in question as obvious, without even mentioning the reason someone might have for doubting it, that won’t be considered good—the fact that this very clever author also treated it as obvious is not a defence. Of course it is completely fine if you say ‘Although someone might doubt this for such-and-such reason, it still seems obvious to me’—and it is *great* if you go on to give an argument that might convince a doubter!

Equally, the lectures will not be a good substitute for doing the readings. I’ll try to zero in on the most crucial and challenging concepts, claims, and arguments; but you can’t really get an adequate grip on a view from a few bullet points on a handout or slide.

4. Preliminary schedule of topics and readings

Sep 4: Introduction

Sep 9 and 11: Metaphysical necessity

Saul Kripke, *Naming and Necessity*, excerpts.

Sep 16 and 18: Debating essentialism

Robert M. Adams, ‘Primitive Thisness and Primitive Identity’

Teresa Robertson, ‘Supplement on Arguments for Origin Essentialism’

Sep 23 and 25: The intersection of metaphysics and modal logic

Timothy Williamson, *Modal logic as Metaphysics*, chapter 1

Sep 30, Oct 2: Time: the block universe versus robust passage

J.J.C. Smart, *Philosophy and Scientific Realism* (excerpt)

A.N.Prior, 'The Notion of the Present'

Kristie Miller, 'In Defence of the Block Universe View'

Oct 7 and 9: Temporal parts and people

David K. Lewis, 'Survival and Identity'

Oct 16 and 18: People and animals

Eric Olson, 'An Argument for Animalism'

Oct 23 and 25: Coincidence and Plenitude

Daniel Korman, 'Strange Kinds, Familiar Kinds, and the Charge of Arbitrariness'

Maegan Fairchild and John Hawthorne, 'Against Conservatism in Metaphysics'

Oct 30 **MIDTERM**

Nov 4 and 6: Natural properties

David K. Lewis, 'New Work for a Theory of Universals'

Ted Sider, 'Crash Course on Naturalness'

Nov 11 and 13: Laws and chance

John Carroll, 'The Humean Tradition'

Helen Beebe, 'The Non-Governing Conception of Laws of Nature'

Nov 18 and 20: Counterfactuals and causation

David K. Lewis, 'Counterfactual Dependence and Time's Arrow'

Christopher Hitchcock, 'The Intransitivity of Causation Revealed in Equations and Graphs'

Nov 25 and 27: Freedom and ability

Peter van Inwagen, 'The Incompatibility of Free Will and Determinism'

Kadri Vihvelin, 'Arguments for Incompatibilism' (SEP article)

Dec 2 and 4: Time travel

David K. Lewis, 'The Paradoxes of Time Travel'

Dec 9 and 11: Overflow, or additional topic TBD

5. Inclusiveness and equality

Discrimination and harassment on the basis of race, gender, sexuality, religion, or other identities will have no place in this class. Please feel free to let us know if you feel that

you have been discriminated against or harassed in any way: we will take complaints seriously and maintain confidentiality insofar as this is consistent with our reporting obligations. Also, as always, you are encouraged to contact the Office of Equal Opportunity

<https://www.nyu.edu/about/policies-guidelines-compliance/equal-opportunity.html>

or to discuss the situation with any NYU faculty or staff member.

6. Academic integrity

Students should be familiar with, and abide by, the College of Arts and Sciences' policy on Academic Integrity, available here

<http://cas.nyu.edu/page/academicintegrity>

7. Students with disabilities

Academic accommodations are available for students with disabilities. To arrange for such accommodations please contact the Moses Center for Students with Disabilities (212-998-4980 or mosescsd@nyu.edu) as early as possible in the semester.